

Ipek Naz Obek

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Education and Professional Experience

Research Technician and Lab Manager Computation, Learning, and Development Lab PI: Dr. Kate Nussenbaum	Boston University	2025–present
B.A., Cognitive Science Concentration: Computation and Cognition Minors: Data Science, Computational Neuroscience <i>Summa Cum Laude; Distinction in Cognitive Science</i> Advisors: Dr. Alison Gopnik, Dr. Sharon Thompson-Schill, Annya Dahmani	University of Pennsylvania	2025
Research Assistant Cognitive Development and Learning Lab PI: Dr. Alison Gopnik; Advisor: Annya Dahmani	University of California, Berkeley	2024–2025
Research Assistant Thompson-Schill & Jenkins Lab PIs: Dr. Sharon Thompson-Schill, Dr. Anna Jenkins	University of Pennsylvania	2024–2025
Research Assistant Center for Neuroengineering and Therapeutics PI: Dr. Brian Litt; Advisor: Dr. James Guggen	University of Pennsylvania	2023

Honors & Awards

Distinction in Cognitive Science Awarded for completing an honors thesis, “Inferring Level Progress in Goal-Directed and Open-Ended Tasks,” and for academic excellence in the major. Thesis advised by Alison Gopnik and Annya Dahmani (UC Berkeley Psychology) and Sharon Thompson-Schill (Penn Psychology).	University of Pennsylvania	2025
Summa Cum Laude Graduated with highest Latin honors from the College of Arts & Sciences; Dean’s List in every academic year, 2021–2025.	University of Pennsylvania	2025
Benjamin Franklin Talk Prize Recognized for the best senior research presentation among the 2025 cohort of Benjamin Franklin Scholars, Penn’s interdisciplinary honors program.	Benjamin Franklin Scholars, University of Pennsylvania	2025
Pinkel Research Fund Research funding awarded to support my senior honors thesis on curriculum learning in humans and machines.	University of Pennsylvania	2025
Lucid Communication Challenge, Engineering and Physical Sciences Talk	Penn National Research Conference	2024

Selected from a field of applicants at the National Research Conference at Penn to present my honors thesis research as a talk.

Benjamin Franklin Research Grant	Benjamin Franklin Scholars, University of Pennsylvania	2024
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Summer research funding awarded by the Benjamin Franklin Scholars Program; supported my research in the Gopnik Cognitive Development and Learning Lab at UC Berkeley.

Career Services Research Grant	Penn Career Services	2024
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Competitive summer funding awarded by Penn Career Services; supported my research in the Gopnik Cognitive Development and Learning Lab at UC Berkeley.

MindCORE Fellowship	MindCORE, University of Pennsylvania	2023
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Selected for a fully funded 10-week summer research program in cognitive science and neuroscience at Penn's hub for the integrative study of the mind.

Undergraduate Research Mentoring Award	Penn Undergraduate Research Mentoring Program	2023
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Fellowship awarded through Penn's Undergraduate Research Mentoring Program, which funds first- and second-year students to conduct summer research with a faculty mentor.

Benjamin Franklin Scholar	University of Pennsylvania	2021–2025
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Member of Penn's interdisciplinary honors program in the liberal arts and sciences.

Manuscripts in Preparation

I. N. Obek, A. Dahmani, & A. Gopnik. *Level Learning Progress*. In prep.

Presentations

Examining the Development of Goal Commitment (Poster) [poster] with: Eleanor Holton, Kate Nussenbaum	Flux Congress, La Jolla, CA	September 2026
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Automated Curriculum Learning in Children and Machines (Poster) [poster] with: Annya Dahmani, Alison Gopnik	Curiosity, Information Seeking, and Exploration Workshop, Brown University, Providence, RI	October 2025
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Automated Curriculum Learning in Children and Machines (Recorded Talk) [video] with: Annya Dahmani, Alison Gopnik	Big Team Science Conference (virtual)	October 2025
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Automated Curriculum Learning in Children and Machines (Poster) [poster] with: Annya Dahmani, Alison Gopnik	Penn National Research Conference, Philadelphia, PA	September 2024
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Understanding the Link Between TBI-Induced Lesions and Epilepsy (Poster) [poster] with: James Gugger, Sahil Narang, Meghana Vasireddy, Chenyu Zhao	MindCORE Research Fellowship Conference, Philadelphia, PA	August 2023
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Research Experience

Computation, Learning, and Development Lab Boston University, Boston, MA Aug 2025–present
Research Technician and Lab Manager
PI: Dr. Kate Nussenbaum

- Lead the design and implementation of online behavioral studies investigating goal pursuit strategies and persistence in children, adolescents, and adults.
- Design and program browser-based behavioral experiments using jsPsych, PsychoPy, and Qualtrics.
- Analyze trial-level behavioral data using mixed-effects models in R to characterize developmental and individual differences in learning and choice.
- Implement computational models of sequential decision-making in Python to test competing accounts of human exploration and value-guided learning.
- As the lab's first lab manager, established experimental, recruitment, and data-collection infrastructure, recruiting over 1,000 participants into the lab's database for developmental studies.
- Organize a biweekly multi-lab journal club bringing together researchers to discuss current papers.

Gopnik Cognitive Development and Learning Lab UC Berkeley, Berkeley, CA Jun 2024–May 2025
Research Assistant
PI: Dr. Alison Gopnik; Advisor: Annya Dahmani

- Designed a novel behavioral paradigm using Progen environments to investigate how people infer learning progress in goal-directed and open-ended tasks.
- Developed computational accounts of learning-progress inference and compared human judgments with reinforcement-learning agents and large language models.
- Designed and analyzed experiments examining how people construct and evaluate curricula for complex, multi-step tasks.
- Recruited families on-site and conducted in-person behavioral testing with children in a museum setting.

Thompson-Schill & Jenkins Lab University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA Jan 2024–May 2025
Research Assistant
PIs: Dr. Sharon Thompson-Schill, Dr. Anna Jenkins

- Conducted honors thesis research, jointly advised across the Thompson-Schill and Gopnik Labs, on human and AI representations of learning progress in goal-directed and open-ended environments.
- Participated in weekly joint lab meetings, discussing current research and literature with faculty and lab members.

Center for Neuroengineering and Therapeutics University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA Jun–Sep 2023
Research Assistant
PI: Dr. Brian Litt; Advisor: Dr. James Guger

- Investigated relationships between traumatic-brain-injury lesion characteristics and subsequent post-traumatic epilepsy using multimodal neuroimaging data.
- Developed Python-based quantitative and machine-learning analyses relating lesion volume and location to clinical outcomes.

- Built an automated pipeline for MRI lesion segmentation and volumetric analysis, reducing reliance on manual annotation.

Teaching

Neuroscience and Society Instructor: Dr. Sharon Thompson-Schill	Teaching Assistant, Penn Undergraduate Program in Neuroscience	2024–2025
Supported students through weekly office hours, in-class instruction, and group activities, and provided individualized academic guidance.		
Introduction to Cognitive Science Instructor: Dr. Russell Richie	Teaching Assistant, Penn Undergraduate Program in Cognitive Science	Fall 2023
Led weekly recitations and office hours for 20+ students, developed instructional materials, and guided students through course concepts and assignments.		
MATH 114: Calculus II	Tutor, Penn Weingarten Tutoring Center	Fall 2022
Tutored first-year students for 4 hours per week, providing individualized support with mathematical problem-solving and study strategies.		

Mentorship

Benjamin Franklin Scholars Mentor Program	Peer Mentor, University of Pennsylvania	2024–2025
Mentored 7 Benjamin Franklin Scholars in their academic and social transition to Penn through regular individual outreach and community-building events.		
Center for Undergraduate Research and Fellowships	Research Peer Advisor, University of Pennsylvania	2024–2025
Advised undergraduates pursuing research opportunities and organized research programming, including an international faculty symposium on the experiences and challenges of international academics.		
Pioneer Academics	Program Coordinator and Advisory Board Member	2022–2025
Advised 100+ students through the research and writing process and coordinated research seminars on effective research practices and faculty mentorship.		
Young Guru Academy	Alumni Mentor	2019–present
Mentor Turkish high school and university students pursuing international education and STEM careers. Led STEM outreach across 5+ cities in rural Anatolia, training teachers and delivering hands-on science education to underserved communities; presented at YGA’s annual summit to ~20,000 attendees.		

Leadership & Service

Cognitive Science Student Association	Founder & President, University of Pennsylvania	2024–2025
Founded and led Penn’s Cognitive Science Student Association, organizing faculty talks, research seminars, mentoring, and networking initiatives connecting students with faculty, alumni, and industry professionals.		
The DREAM Program	Recruitment Chair, Philadelphia, PA	2023–2025

Led volunteer recruitment and weekly educational programming for preschool-aged children in West Philadelphia, including hands-on science activities designed to foster curiosity, collaboration, and confidence in learning.

Turkish Student Association	President,	2022–2025
	University of Pennsylvania	

Directed a 50-member organization and community initiatives, including raising \$8K for earthquake-relief efforts.

Assembly of International Students	Social Committee Member,	2021–2025
	University of Pennsylvania	

Organized social and cultural programming to foster community among Penn’s international student population.

The Daily Pennsylvanian	Photographer,	2021–2025
	University of Pennsylvania	

Photographed campus events and contributed visual content for multimedia stories at Penn’s student newspaper.

Skills

Programming: Python, R, JavaScript, MATLAB, SQL, Java, OCaml

Research tools & platforms: jsPsych, PsychoPy, Qualtrics, Prolific, Pavlovia, Git/GitHub, Jupyter, LaTeX, AFNI

Certifications: CITI Training (Biomedical Responsible Conduct of Research; Human Subjects Research; Social-Behavioral Research with Children)

Languages: Turkish (native), English (fluent), French (fluent; Certificate in French, University of Pennsylvania)

References

Dr. Kate Nussenbaum	Boston University
Assistant Professor, Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences	katenuss@bu.edu

Dr. Alison Gopnik	University of California, Berkeley
Professor of Psychology	gopnik@berkeley.edu

Dr. Sharon Thompson-Schill	University of Pennsylvania
Christopher H. Browne Distinguished Professor of Psychology; Co-Director, Center for Cognitive Neuroscience	sschill@psych.upenn.edu

Dr. Russell Richie	University of Pennsylvania
Associate Director, Cognitive Science and MindCORE	drussellmrchie@gmail.com

Annya Dahmani	University of California, Berkeley
PhD Student, Department of Psychology (advised by Alison Gopnik)	adahmani@berkeley.edu